1. **Generate a Spring Boot Project**
   Use the official Spring Initializr web tool to bootstrap your project. Configure the following options:

   a. **Project**: Maven

   b. **Language**: Java

   c. **Spring Boot**: Select the latest stable version

   d. **Group**: com.example (or your preferred package name)

   e. **Artifact**: demo (or your project name)

   f. **Dependencies**: Click "Add Dependencies" and select **Spring Web**

Click the **Generate** button to download a ZIP file. Extract this file and import the project into your favorite IDE (IntelliJ, Eclipse, or VS Code).

2. **Create a REST Controller**
   Navigate to the main application package (src/main/java/com/example/demo in this example) and create a new Java class, for instance, HelloWorldController.java. Add the following code:

   java
```
package com.example.demo;

import org.springframework.web.bind.annotation.GetMapping;
import org.springframework.web.bind.annotation.RestController;

@RestController
public class HelloWorldController {

  @GetMapping("/hello")
  public String hello() {
    return "Hello World!";
  }
}
```

1. @RestController marks the class as a controller that handles web requests and returns the domain object directly as the response body.
2. @GetMapping("/hello") maps HTTP GET requests for the /hello path to this specific method.

3. **Run the Application**
   The generated project includes a main application class annotated with @SpringBootApplication and a main() method, which serves as the entry point.

1. **From your IDE**: Right-click the main application class (e.g., DemoApplication.java) and select "Run".

2. **From the command line**: Open a terminal in the project's root directory and run the command: mvn spring-boot:run.

Spring Boot will start an embedded Tomcat server, by default on port 8080.

4. **Test the API**
   Open a web browser or use a tool like Postman or curl to access the endpoint:http://localhost:8080/hello You should see the "Hello World!" message as the response.